

Plytix Design Team

Image Optimization & Alt Text Guide

Standards & best practices for WordPress — 2026

This guide covers everything the Design team needs to know about preparing, naming, compressing, and tagging images for **WordPress** in 2026. Following these standards keeps our site fast, accessible, and search-optimised.

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1. Optimizing Image Files

Before uploading anything to WordPress, every image must go through the following preparation steps.

Step 1 — Choose the right format

Format	Use For	Notes
JPG / JPEG	Photos, screenshots with backgrounds	Most photographic content; good compression

Format	Use For	Notes
WebP	All web images where possible	Best compression + quality ratio; use as default
PNG	Transparent backgrounds, UI elements	Only when transparency is required
SVG	Icons, logos, illustrations, diagrams	Infinitely scalable; no quality loss
GIF → WebP	Animated content	Convert all GIFs to WebP via EZgif

Step 2 — Compress before uploading

Every image must be compressed, even if it looks small. Aim for under 150 KB. Smaller is always better for Core Web Vitals.

Recommended compression tools

ImageOptim — imageoptim.com (JPG, PNG)

Squoosh — squoosh.app (WebP, best quality control)

TinyPNG / TinyJPG — tinypng.com (WebP, JPG, PNG)

EZgif — ezgif.com/gif-to-webp (GIF → WebP conversion)

⚠️ Unsure if it was already compressed? Run it through a tool anyway — a second pass on an already-compressed file does no harm.

Step 3 — Name your files properly

File names are indexed by search engines and must be descriptive, lowercase, and dash-separated.

a	Use dashes (-) to separate words. No spaces, underscores, or camelCase.
	✓ plytix-pim-dashboard-overview.png ✗ Screenshot_Final_v3.png
b	For blog post or landing page images, use the URL slug + a number suffix.
	✓ product-information-management-guide-1.webp ✗ image_hero_final2.jpg
c	For infographics and elaborate visuals, describe the content.
	✓ pim-vs-erp-comparison-infographic.png ✗ infographic-v2.png

2. Alt Text: What It Is & Why It Matters

Alt text (the **alt** attribute) is a short description attached to every image. It serves three purposes: accessibility for screen reader users, a fallback when images fail to load, and a contextual signal for search engines including Google Images.

Accessibility

Screen readers read alt text aloud so visually impaired users understand what's on screen.

SEO

Search engines use alt text to understand image content and boost page relevance for target keywords.

Fallback

If an image fails to load, the alt text appears in its place so the content still makes sense.

AEO

AI answer engines parse alt text when generating responses. Descriptive alt text increases the chance your content is cited or surfaced in AI-generated answers.

3. How to Write Alt Text

3.1 When to add alt text

Not every image needs alt text. Use this decision guide:

 Always add alt text	 Leave alt blank (decorative)
Product screenshots	Purely decorative background shapes
Infographics and diagrams	Decorative dividers or spacer images
Logos (when meaningful)	Icons next to USP bullets (not standalone)
Charts and data visuals	Repeating pattern / texture backgrounds
UI element callouts	Images that are fully explained in body text

3.2 The golden rules

Rule	Why It Matters	✓ Good / ✗ Bad
Be concise	Screen readers truncate after ~125 characters. Long alt text annoys users.	✓ "Plytix PIM dashboard showing sync status for 452 products." ✗ (Multi-sentence description of every pixel)
Be accurate	Alt text must replace the image. If it loads, the user should picture it.	✓ "Plytix Shopify channel run: 452 products synced successfully." ✗ "A screenshot of a computer screen with numbers."
Start with the subject	No fluff intro phrases.	✓ "Plytix PIM dashboard..." ✗ "Image of a Plytix PIM dashboard..."
Include key on-screen text	Any visible text that carries meaning must be in the alt.	✓ "Error banner: 'SKU field is required' in attribute editor." ✗ "Screenshot of an error message."
Describe the action	For instructional screenshots, the action is what matters.	✓ "Selecting 'Add channel' in Settings → Channels." ✗ "Cursor on a menu item."
No keyword stuffing	Use keywords naturally where relevant. Never cram them in.	✓ "Plytix PIM product attributes mapped to WooCommerce fields." ✗ "PIM product information management software WooCommerce Shopify..."
Mention color only if meaningful	Color that conveys status is worth noting. Decorative color is not.	✓ "Green status badge: Synced successfully." ✗ "Blue and green dashboard with lots of sections."
Describe buttons and icons by function	Don't describe what they look like—say what they do.	✓ "Download scorecard" / "Open settings" ✗ "Button" / "Icon"
Capitalise the first letter	Consistent with standard sentence rules.	✓ "Plytix PIM dashboard..." ✗ "plytix pim dashboard..."
Use captions for longer context	Captions supplement; they don't replace alt text.	✓ Short alt text + caption that adds detail below the image. ✗ Stuffing a paragraph into the alt field.

4. Alt Text Examples

Use these examples as a reference when tagging any image type in WordPress.

Screenshots & UI

✓ Good Alt Text	✗ Bad Alt Text
Plytix PIM dashboard showing successful sync for 452 products.	Screenshot of a computer screen.
Selecting 'Add channel' in Settings → Channels to create a new integration.	Cursor on a menu.
Error banner: 'SKU is required' displayed in the attribute editor.	Screenshot of an error message.

Logos & Brand Marks

✓ Good Alt Text	✗ Bad Alt Text
Plytix PIM logo.	Logo
WooCommerce logo.	Image of a logo icon.

Infographics & Diagrams

✓ Good Alt Text	✗ Bad Alt Text
Step-by-step diagram: PIM setup in 5 stages from data import to channel publishing.	Infographic about PIM.
Comparison chart: PIM vs ERP — 10 key differences across data, speed, and integrations.	A chart showing some differences.

People & Photos

✓ Good Alt Text	✗ Bad Alt Text
Plytix customer success manager reviewing product data in PIM.	A person at a desk.
Team photo at Plytix Copenhagen office.	People.

5. Uploading & Tagging Images in WordPress

5.1 Folder & file naming in the Media Library

WordPress does not have native folder support in its Media Library. Use a plugin such as Real Media Library to create organised folders. Name folders by content type:

- blog / [post-slug] e.g. blog/what-is-a-pim
- landing-pages / [page-slug] e.g. landing-pages/shopify-connector
- resources / [type] e.g. resources/infographics
- social / [year-month] e.g. social/2026-03

5.2 Adding alt text when uploading

Every time you upload an image in WordPress, add alt text before closing the media modal. There are three places where this comes up:

A	Media Library upload Media → Add New → select image → fill in “Alt Text” field in the right-hand panel before saving.
B	Block editor (Gutenberg) in-content images Click the image block → open “Block” tab in the right sidebar → fill in “Alt Text (alternative text)”.
C	Featured images In the post editor → “Post” tab in sidebar → “Featured image” → click image → update alt text in the media modal. Consider using the blog title or focus keyword.
D	Theme builder / page builder images (Elementor, Kadence, etc.) Click the image widget → open widget settings panel → locate “Alt Text” or “Caption” field. Check inside expandable subsections if not immediately visible.

5.3 Lazy loading

Enable **lazy loading** on all images. In Gutenberg, check “Lazy load” in the image block settings. Most caching/performance plugins (e.g. WP Rocket, Perfmatters) handle this globally — verify it is active. Lazy loading is also required for any embedded videos in blog posts.

5.4 Replacing an existing image

- 1 Navigate to the page or post containing the image and click Edit.
- 2 Select the image block and click "Replace" (or upload a new file to Media Library first).
- 3 Delete any link that may have been attached to the old image.
- 4 Update the alt text to match the new image.
- 5 Re-enable lazy load if the block setting was reset.
- 6 Publish / update the post.

6. Design Guidelines Reference

The following table summarises the full set of rules referenced in this guide. Use it as a quick daily reference.

Rule	Why It Matters	✓ Good / ✗ Bad
Filenames	Makes assets searchable, reusable, and signals content to search engines.	✓ plytix-pim-woocommerce-connector.png ✗ screenshot_v2_final.png
Contextual placement	Reduces cognitive load. Images should be directly beside the step they illustrate.	✓ Screenshot sits directly under the step it illustrates. ✗ Screenshot appears 6 sections later.
Alt text required	Common accessibility gap. Every meaningful image needs alt text.	✓ Alt text added to screenshots, diagrams, and icons. ✗ No alt text on key visuals.
Skip decorative alt	Screen readers don't need noise from purely decorative elements.	✓ Background shapes left with blank alt (alt=""). ✗ Decorative flourishes described as real content.
Describe purpose	If the image doesn't load, alt text must replace it meaningfully.	✓ "Plytix PIM dashboard showing successful sync." ✗ "A screenshot of a computer screen with numbers."
Subject-first format	No filler intro phrases.	✓ "Shopify channel status: 452 products synced." ✗ "Image of a Shopify channel run..."

Rule	Why It Matters	✓ Good / ✗ Bad
Under ~125 chars	Screen readers truncate longer text.	✓ "Plytix Shopify channel status: 452 products synced." ✗ (Long sentence describing every UI element)
Include key text	On-screen text that carries meaning must appear in alt.	✓ "Error banner: 'SKU is required' on screen." ✗ "Screenshot of an error message."
Describe actions	For instructional images the action is the point.	✓ "Selecting 'Add channel' in Settings → Channels." ✗ "Cursor on a menu."
SEO / AEO	Use keywords naturally; never stuff.	✓ "Plytix PIM product attributes mapped to WooCommerce." ✗ (Keyword-stuffed nonsense)
Buttons / Icons	Describe their function, not their appearance.	✓ "Download scorecard" / "Open settings" ✗ "Button" / "Icon"
Capitalisation	Start with a capital letter.	✓ "Plytix PIM dashboard..." ✗ "plytix pim dashboard..."
Color	Only mention color when it carries meaning (e.g. status badges).	✓ "Green status badge: Synced successfully." ✗ "Blue and green screen with lots of sections."
Captions	Use captions when more explanation is needed; keep alt brief.	✓ Short alt + caption that adds detail below. ✗ Stuffing a paragraph into alt text.

7. Pre-Upload Checklist

Run through this list every time you prepare an image for WordPress.

Image checklist

- ✓ Format is WebP, JPG, PNG, or SVG (as appropriate)
- ✓ File size is under 150 KB
- ✓ File has been run through a compression tool
- ✓ Filename uses lowercase, dashes only, is descriptive
- ✓ Alt text is written (if image is meaningful)

- ✓ Alt text is under 125 characters
- ✓ Alt text starts with the subject (no "Image of")
- ✓ Alt text includes any key on-screen text
- ✓ Decorative-only images have blank alt (alt="")
- ✓ Lazy load is enabled on the image block or globally